

Axiologically Opposed Adjectives

New insights into thick terms

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Joint work - *in progress!* -
with **Anouch Bourmayan**
(Sorbonne)



cf. Bourmayan, A. (2025):

**AXIOLOGICALLY OPPOSITE ADJECTIVES IN
FRENCH: A NEW ILLUSTRATION OF THE
GOLDILOCKS PRINCIPLE**

an example of axiological opposites

(83y old man goes into a house on fire to save a little kitten)

A: What he did was **brave**.

I: What he did was **foolhardy**.



another example

A: His decision
was **brave**.

I: His decision
was **foolhardy**.

ANALYSIS

Macron is either brave or foolhardy as he tries to get the French to work for longer

An explosive year lies ahead as the last time these policies were tried there were months of industrial unrest and protests.



Ian King
Business presenter @iankingsky

🕒 Tuesday 10 January 2023 14:36, UK



Plan for the talk

- ❖ Intro: Axiological opposites and thick terms
- ❖ A presuppositional account
- ❖ A Goldilocks account
- ❖ Pros and cons for (and against) each account
- ❖ Wrap up: Rethinking positivity

Introduction

Axiologically opposed adjectives
(AOAs) as a subclass of thick terms

Thick terms

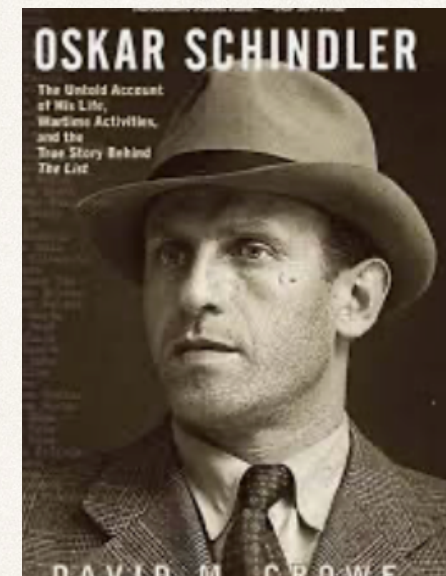
- ❖ Thick terms (a.k.a thick *concepts*) are contrasted with thin terms, such as 'good', 'great', 'bad' and 'awful'. The latter's function is to evaluate, while the former have both a descriptive and an evaluative component
- ❖ Thick terms have been hardly discussed in linguistics, but have so widely in moral philosophy. Lots of open questions, in particular, whether the descriptive and the evaluative can be teased apart, and how do thick terms encode or convey evaluation

Axiological opposites

- ❖ Historically, Oscar Ducrot (with Jean-Claude Anscombe) discussed pairs such as *courageux-téméraire* in *Les échelles argumentatives* (1983) in terms of argumentative orientation
- ❖ And Bernard Williams, in *Ethics and the Limits of Philosophy* (1985) talks about different evaluative outlooks, but argues that thick concepts cannot be decomposed into a descriptive and an evaluative component

AOAs: a working definition

- ❖ Intuitively, two terms (or concepts) are axiological opposites when the difference in their meaning can be *best* explained by appeal to the evaluative dimension
- ❖ E.g. A **brave** person is ready to face danger, and so is a **foolhardy** person, but the brave one does it **in a good way**, and the foolhardy one, in a **bad** (or reckless) way



Brad David (as Billy Hayes)
in *Midnight Express*

Tentative examples of AOAAs

confident-arrogant

trusting-credulous

idealistic-naïve

devout-fanatical

determined-stubborn

meticulous-nitpicky

frugal-stingy

colorful-garish

generous-prodigal

outstanding-abnormal

versatility of AOOs

- ❖ The associated value needn't be moral: eg 'garish' is similar to 'colorful', but in an ugly way
- ❖ Languages can differ in how they lexicalise AOOs. E.g. in Serbian, no straightforward translation for 'foolhardy', but yes for eg 'frugal'-'stingy'



Leonid Afremov, *Burst of Colour*

Section 1

A presuppositional account of
thick terms (incl. AOAAs)

Cepollaro & Stojanovic (2016)

Hybrid Evaluatives

A presuppositional account both for **slurs** and **thick terms** (we call them “hybrid evaluatives”: terms that are in part descriptive in part evaluative. (Here I’ll bracket slurs).

Roughly, a term like “brave” has a (difficult to pin down) descriptive content; smth like “ready to face and/or endure danger or pain”, but also triggers an *evaluative* presupposition, which may be glossed as “in general, whoever is face and endure danger or pain is **good** in some relevant way”.

evaluative presuppositions project

1. Is Macron brave?
2. Macron isn't brave.
3. If Macron were brave, he would have consulted with the syndicates.
4. My roommate votes for Macron because she finds him brave.

(1)-(4) all support the inference that
being brave is a way of being good.

presupposition failure leads to lack of truth value

- ❖ Some thick terms carry pre-suppositions we don't endorse
- ❖ (?) Was Kate Middleton chaste when she married Prince William?
- ❖ Oscar Wilde's at his trial for *The Importance of Being Earnest*:
«*Blasphemy* is not a word of mine. »



evaluative presuppositions are different from factual presuppositions

- ❖ « Macron's brave decision to implement this new retirement policy will impact the country's economy »
- ❖ « Hey, wait a minute! I didn't know he decided to go ahead and implement it. »
- ❖ ?? / # « Hey, wait a minute! I didn't know that facing danger by implementing such a policy was good ».
- ❖ « Hey, wait a minute! Do you really think that implementing this dangerous policy was a good decision ? »

applying the account to AOAAs

- ❖ brave:= ready to face danger
def. iff being ready to face danger is **good**
- ❖ foolhardy:= ready to face danger
def. iff being ready to face danger is **bad**
- ❖ generous:= willing to give without expecting anything in return
def. iff willing to give without exp.(...) is **good**
- ❖ prodigal:= willing to give without expecting anything in return
def. iff willing to give without exp.(...) is **bad**

can the same thing be both good and bad?

- ❖ Yes, because good and bad are **highly underspecified**, and the presupposed content can only be fleshed out contextually
- ❖ E.g. is it good that it rained in Paris on 26 July 2024? Well, yes and no...



presuppositional account: what matters, and what doesn't matter

- ❖ It doesn't matter that valence should be conveyed *via* presuppositions (esp. since evaluative presuppositions aren't like other better studied presuppositions); (alternatives: conventional or gen. conv. implicature)
- ❖ It matters that valence should be projective
- ❖ It also matters that competence with a given evaluative word entails knowledge about the associated valence

Section 2

A Goldilocks account of AOAAs

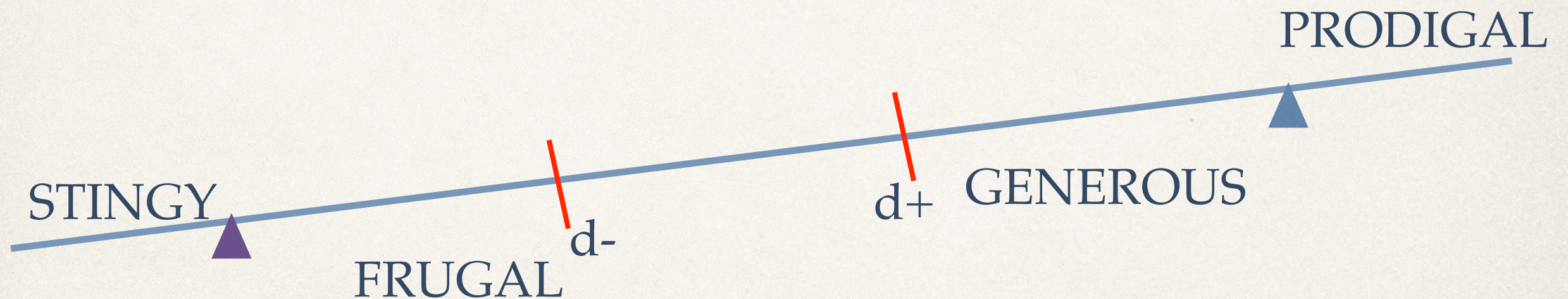
Bourmayan (2025)

« $A+$ and $A-$ in fact do not have the same referential content: they are gradable adjectives and are associated with similar scales, that is, scales involving the same dimension, degrees and ordering relation. But they differ with respect to the standard of comparison they involve: $A+$ encode a contextually determined standard of comparison d' , and $A-$ a contextually determined standard of comparison d'' that is strictly higher than d' and marks excess. On this analysis, $A+$ are open scale adjectives, but $A-$ behave like lower closed scale adjectives. »

taking scalar structure into account

- ❖ a first shot at the idea (...but can't be entirely correct)

dimension: ratio of willingness to give w.r.t. expectation of benefit



the Goldilocks principle

- ❖ Nouwen (2024, ms.) appeals to the Goldilocks principle to correlate excess and negative valence
- ❖ In relation to moral value, this correlates with the Aristotelian conception of virtue as « the golden mean »
- ❖ Excess is typically negative, the excess marker 'too' (as in 'too hot', 'too bright', 'too expansive') conveys negative implicature



Section 3

Pros and Cons

subtle linguistic data

Reported asymmetries (1st: Carel 2017, 2nd: Bourmayan 2025)

- ❖ That man was brave, and even foolhardy. vs.
?? That man was foolhardy, and even brave.
Cet homme a été courageux, et même téméraire.
?? Cet homme a été téméraire, et même courageux.
- ❖ She was brave, but not foolhardy. vs.
?? She was foolhardy, but not brave.
Elle a été courageuse, mais pas téméraire.
?? Elle a été téméraire, mais pas courageuse.

felicity judgments will vary with AOA pairs, and presumably context as well

- ❖ The painting is colorful, and even garish. It's colorful but not garish.
The painting is garish, and even colorful. # It's garish but not colorful.
- ❖ Leila is generous, and even prodigal. vs.
Leila is prodigal, and even generous.
- ❖ Ahmed is frugal, but not stingy.
Ahmed is stingy, but not frugal.
- ❖ Interim explanations: colorful is neutral rather than positive;
and frugal / prodigal / stingy / generous don't refer to the same kind of
behavior: the latter have a moral dimension, viz. caring about others

A+ and even A-, A+ but not A-

- ❖ The Goldilocks account has a straightforward explanation: the « positive » adjective is not really positive, but neutral, and the negative marks excess
- ❖ X is A, and even excessively A vs.
?X is excessively A, and even A. (redundant)
- ❖ X is A, but not excessively A. vs.
#A is excessively A, but not A. (contradictory)

A+ and even A-: what's 'even' doing? Pragmatic repair

- ❖ The presuppositional account doesn't have a ready-at-hand explanation of the asymmetry. But here is a tentative one.
- ❖ That man was brave, and even foolhardy.
- ❖ Taken at face value:
That man was ready to face danger, and even ready to face danger.
 - ▲ Ready to face danger is good, and ready to face danger is bad.
- ❖ That man was ready to face danger, and even foolish in doing so.
 - ▲ Ready to face danger is mostly good, but can sometimes be bad.



disagreement data

confident-**arrogant**, idealistic-**naïve**, determined-**stubborn**, frugal-**stingy**, generous-**prodigal**,
trusting-**credulous**, devout-**fanatical**, meticulous-**nitpicky**, colorful-**garish**, outstanding-**abnormal**

A+ but not A- is in general better than A- but not A+

It's significantly improved if you remove 'but':

« She's arrogant, not confident ». « That's not colorful, that's garish! »

However, it's unclear that disagreement always has to be metalinguistic:

« Was that man brave? » « No, he wasn't. »

Goldilocks predicts that the negation is metalinguistic (ie don't use 'brave' use a stronger alternative: « Was it good? No, it wasn't. It was excellent. »)

Presupp. account predicts that the negation targets the presupposition.

excess, extremeness and deviation

- ❖ The Goldilocks account predicts the following two:
- ❖ If X is courageous / generous / meticulous, and Y is foolhardy / prodigal / nitpicky, it follows that:
Y is more courageous / generous / meticulous than Y
- ❖ If X is extremely brave, X is closer to being foolhardy than Y who is less brave than X but is less cautious, doesn't foresee risks, and is a bit stupid

outstanding, exceptional and abnormal

- ❖ how would the Goldilocks account explain these AOAs? (note: these aren't thick terms)
- ❖ some deviations from the norm can be bad (e.g. being obese, having high blood pressure etc.), but not all have to be (e.g. exceptionally high IQ, ability to swim 500km non-stop (Martin Strel), originality...)
- ❖ on the presuppositional account, word choice signals whether the deviation (excess) is good or bad

wrap up

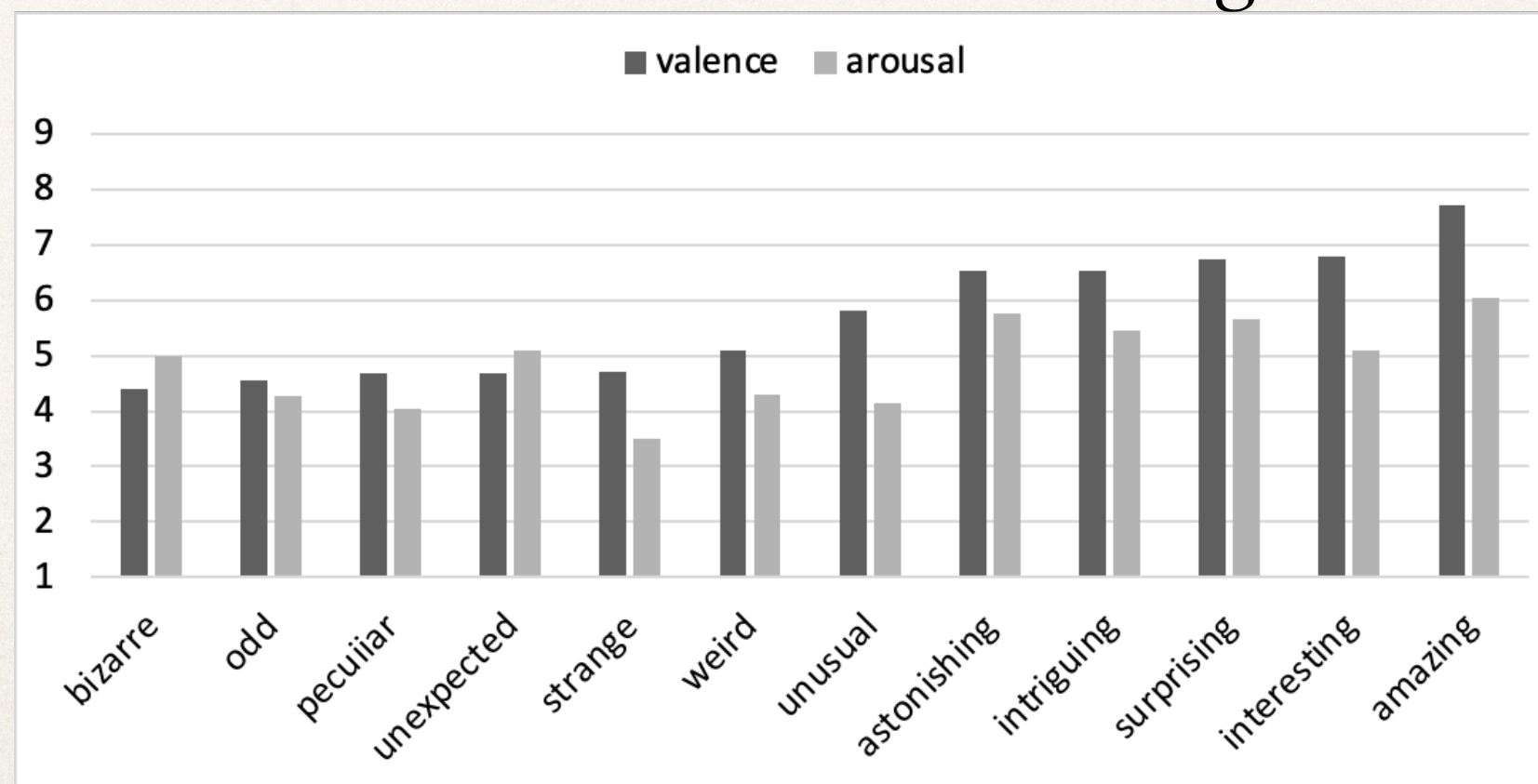
rethinking positivity

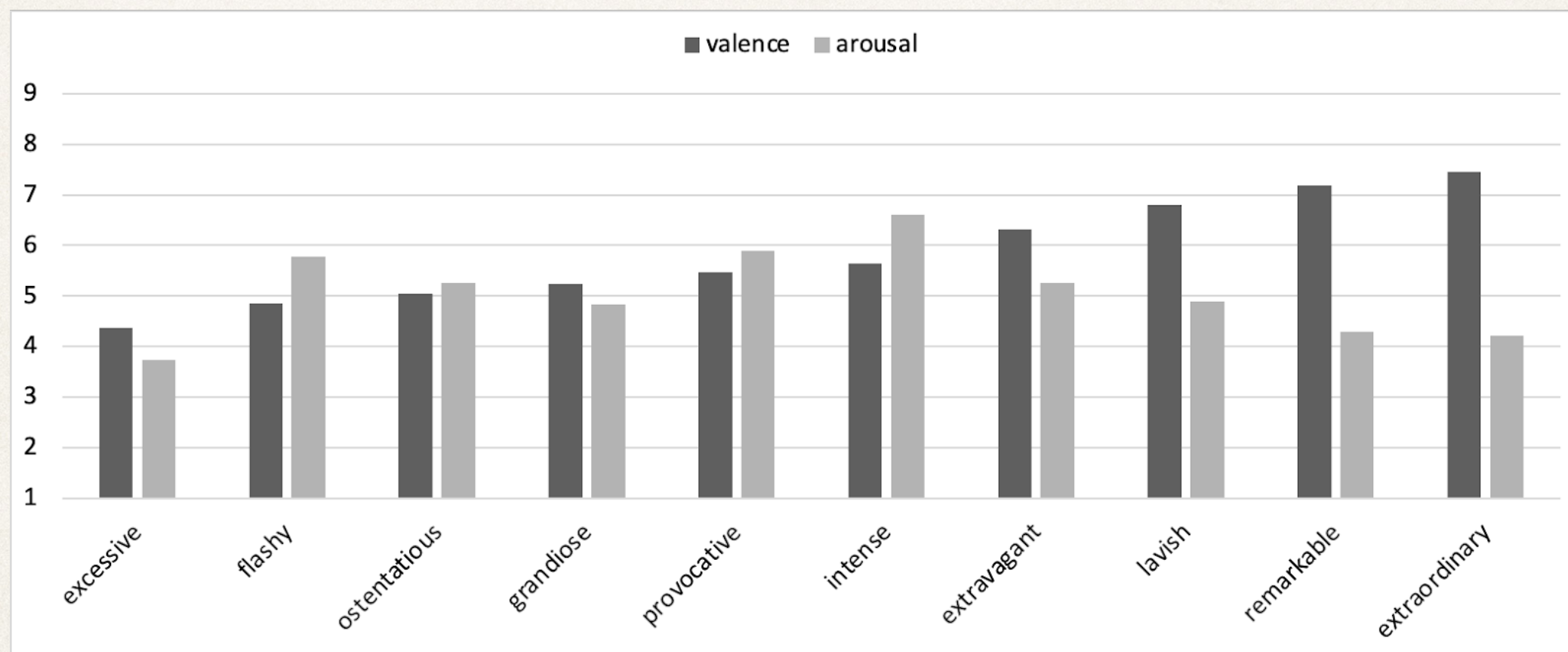
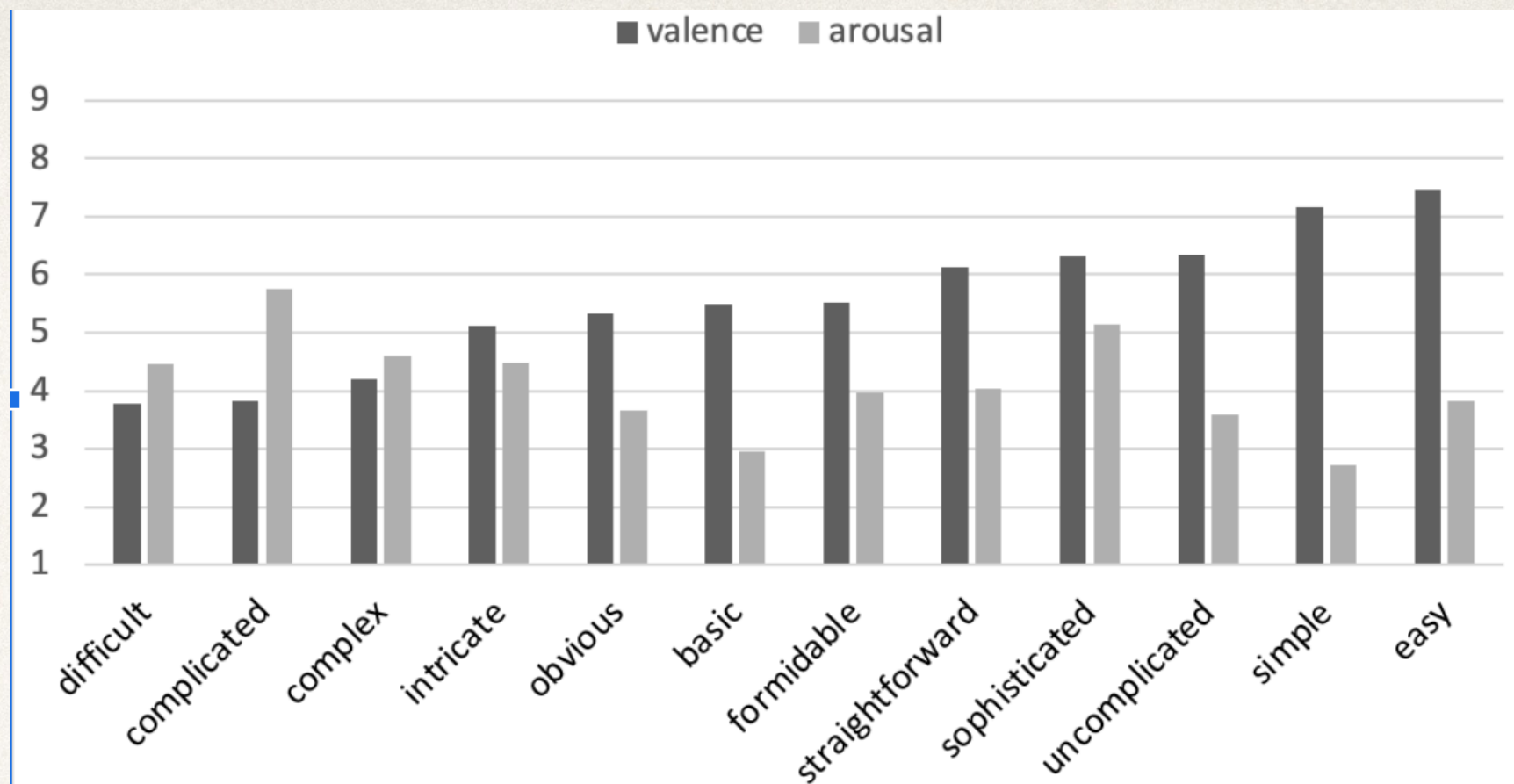
both account is onto something

- ❖ The two accounts can complement each other, since each tracks an interesting phenomenon
- ❖ The Goldilocks account nicely captures adjective pairs where one adjective is neutral, ie positive in the sense of unmarked (not valence), and the other negative
- ❖ The presuppositional account tracks the idea that when we use a thick term, we commit to classifying, a given type of action, behavior, personality, or whatever, as good or bad

positive or neutral?

- ❖ In Stojanovic and Kaiser (2022), *Exploring Valence in Judgments of Taste*, we highlighted neutral adjectives: those that, in VAD norms, sit close to the middle, and are felicitous when modified with ‘*in a good/bad way*’





a bigger picture

- ❖ Many among such neutral adjectives are used to express value judgments, but they only acquire their (positive or negative) valence in a context
- ❖ Predicates that tend to convey negative valence (incl. deviation and excess) end up encoding it lexically; lexical valence behaves as a kind of projective content
- ❖ Presumably the same holds for positive valence. However...

bad is stronger than good

- ❖ Baumeister, R. F., Bratslavsky, E., Finkenauer, C., & Vohs, K. D. (2001). Bad is stronger than good. *Review of General Psychology*, 5, 323-370
- ❖ Positive implications are easier to override than negative ones
- ❖ Willemsen et al. (2024) show that for positive thick moral terms ('brave', 'generous') the evaluation inference is easier to cancel than for negative
- ❖ Cassani and Colombo (2026) didn't replicate this asymmetry (but that could be due to the difference in study design)

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Evaluative Deflation, Social Expectations, and the Zone of Moral Indifference

[Pascale Willemsen](#)  [Lucien Baumgartner](#), [Bianca Cepollaro](#), [Kevin Reuter](#)

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by way of conclusion

- ❖ AOAs are intriguing, because they overlap in terms of descriptive meaning, but convey different evaluations
- ❖ On the Goldilocks account, the « positive » is, really, neutral, and the negative is so because it encodes excess
- ❖ But it isn't always a matter of excess or deviation: first, deviation (and even excess) doesn't have to be negative; second, it isn't always a matter of degree, but often of manner (garish:=colorful *in a bad way*), outcome, or intention
- ❖ The negative overrides the positive more easily than converse, because the positive is the prevalent, the expected, the unmarked

Thank you
for your
attention!

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extra slide: the stimuli in Cassani & Colombo (2026)

Table 1

Summary of key variables manipulated in stimuli for Experiment 1.

Sentence	Adjective type	Adjective polarity	Expected contradiction	Thick Domain
Jason is selfless; by that I am not saying something positive about him.	thick	positive	contradictory	moral
The decor is hideous; by that I am not saying something positive about it.	thick	negative	noncontradictory	aesthetic
John is unemployed; by that I am not saying something positive about him.	non-thick	negative	noncontradictory	none
The salad is seasoned; by that I am not saying something positive about it.	non-thick	positive	contradictory	none

Note: The same schema applies to experiments conducted in Italian and Dutch. “Non-Thick” refers to terms we classified as non-thick descriptive adjectives.